

Business Activity Survey: follow up schedule for 2026

Schedule adopted. Table 1 is the schedule put to the Board, compiled under COS 2019 from the returns received in 2025 on the only compilation that reproduces all 24 published means: one observation per form, timed from the earliest dispatch, relief returns excluded. It keeps 7,326 of the 7,574 forms received in 2025.

Stratum	p50 boundary	day	p90 boundary	day	2025 p50	2025 p90	move p50	move p90
MFG	4,670	4	10,690	8	4,600	10,050	+1.5%	+6.4%
CON	7,260	6	15,390	11	7,270	16,020	-0.1%	-3.9%
WRT	3,000	3	6,660	5	3,110	6,940	-3.5%	-4.0%
TRS	5,790	5	13,100	10	5,510	11,710	+5.1%	+11.9%
ACC	10,290	8	21,630	16	9,990	20,550	+3.0%	+5.3%
PRO	2,080	2	5,370	4	2,040	4,970	+2.0%	+8.0%
ALL	5,070	4	13,630	10	4,860	13,190	+4.3%	+3.3%

Compilation basis. Elapsed time is whole minutes from dispatch to receipt, counted in the year of receipt (clause 2). The standard does not say what the observation is or which returns count, so both were settled by clause 6: each reading of the records was run back over 2021 to 2024 and compared with the Bulletin. One observation per form received, timed from the earliest dispatch the form closes (enterprises with several reporting units return one combined form), with forms excluded where the dispatch fell inside the enterprise's burden relief window (register dates, both ends inclusive), reproduces every published mean to the minute. The reading the record layout invites, one observation per dispatch line with every return kept, reproduces 19 of 24; correcting either the unit or the population alone reproduces 15 and 15, so neither correction can be tested on its own. Dropping reissued dispatches reproduces 1. Boundaries follow clause 4: rank ceiling of a times n over b, no interpolation, rounded up to the next 10 minutes; reminder day is the boundary over 1,440 rounded up.

Annex A. Published means beside the compiled means, minutes.

Stratum	2021 pub.	2021 comp.	diff	2022 pub.	2022 comp.	diff	2023 pub.	2023 comp.	diff	2024 pub.	2024 comp.	diff
MFG	5,415	5,415	0	5,475	5,475	0	5,335	5,335	0	5,489	5,489	0
CON	8,489	8,489	0	8,092	8,092	0	8,743	8,743	0	8,689	8,689	0
WRT	3,682	3,682	0	3,567	3,567	0	3,565	3,565	0	3,810	3,810	0
TRS	5,985	5,985	0	6,325	6,325	0	6,293	6,293	0	6,576	6,576	0
ACC	11,882	11,882	0	11,555	11,555	0	11,636	11,636	0	11,660	11,660	0
PRO	2,386	2,386	0	2,624	2,624	0	2,503	2,503	0	2,565	2,565	0

Closest reading that does not stand. One observation per dispatch line with every return kept misses five published means (differences of 488, 75, 30, 78, 79 minutes) and cannot reach the Board under clause 6.2. Its 2025 schedule parts from the adopted one by: MFG p50 -40; MFG p90 +390; CON p50 -30; CON p90 +230; WRT p50 -30; WRT p90 +170; TRS p50 +0; TRS p90 +350; ACC p50 +70; ACC p90 +710; PRO p50 -10; PRO p90 +20; ALL p50 -60; ALL p90 +340 minutes. The widest gap is ACC p90, +710 minutes.

Furthest movement. TRS moves furthest against the standing schedule, 11.9 per cent at p90 (11,710 to 13,100 minutes). Its reminder day is 10; day 10 holds for any boundary above 12,960 minutes up to and including 14,400, so the boundary would have to fall to 12,960 or below to come forward a day, or rise above 14,400 to move out a day.

Returns that would have drawn follow up. Of the 2025 returns in the schedule population, the number received after the boundary, that is the number a reminder or escalation would have gone to, under the new boundaries and under the standing ones: MFG p50 623 against 633; MFG p90 124 against 147; CON p50 559 against 557; CON p90 110 against 100; WRT p50 610 against 584; WRT p90 122 against 111; TRS p50 628 against 679; TRS p90 125 against 164; ACC p50 631 against 658; ACC p90 126 against 148; PRO p50 604 against 622; PRO p90 120 against 146; ALL p50 3,659 against 3,792; ALL p90 730 against 781. The survey wide first reminder would have gone to 3,659 returns under the new boundary against 3,792 under the standing one.

The 2018 parameter sheet predates the standard (p60 and p95 shares, 15 minute rounding, two pooled years, questionnaire unit) and has no use under COS 2019; the standing schedule is not carried forward by default (clause 6.3), and is not needed, since an admissible compilation exists.

